

How I Became a Ghost Ch. 15-16

By Tim Tingle





Chapter 15

The Bending Branch of Treaty Talk

"I LEARNED SOMETHING else," Joseph said. "Our leaders are with us."

"What do you mean?" I asked him.

"Not every Choctaw is walking. Behind the lead wagons, there is another wagon. Choctaw councilmen ride in this wagon. It is not big enough for all of them, so some walk while the others ride. They switch out several times a day, when someone is too tired to walk.

"They can't know everything the soldiers do, but they watch them. That is why the soldiers bring us milk and corn. They have to feed us. They have to keep us safe."

"Why?" I asked.

“That is what the treaty says,” Joseph said. “They have to take us safely to our new home in the west. That was what they agreed, at the Treaty Talk.”

“I wish I never heard of Treaty Talk,” I said. “Before Treaty Talk, we had our homes. With no Treaty Talk, Old Man and Old Woman would still be alive, and Nita and Mister and Missus Jonah, too.”

Joseph lowered his eyes and looked away without responding. I wished I hadn't mentioned his grandparents, Old Man and Old Woman. I could see it made him sad to think of them, burning in the fire.

“What should we do?” I finally asked.

“We should help Naomi escape. The soldiers cut her hair. They make her wear boy's clothes. She does everything for them, just like I did. She cooks their meals. She washes their clothes. She feeds their horses.”

“Do you have a plan?”

“Yes,” Joseph replied. “The best plan of all. We wait. We stay close and watch and we wait.”

“We wait for a sign,” I said.

“Yes,” he said. “You are a smart young man.”

“Do you know about me?” I had to ask him.

Joseph smiled and nodded. “Yes,” he said. “Why do you think I wanted your help? Your brother, Luke, is bigger and faster. I asked you to help because you see ghosts. And a ghost will bring you a sign.”

We did not have long to wait.

I followed Joseph to a creek a half-mile from camp. We found a tree with thick limbs hanging almost to the ground. He grabbed the lowest limb and swung himself from one limb to the next till he was out of sight.

“Come on up,” he said. “Nobody can see us here.” I gripped the limb and was about to climb, when the warm shiver came.

“Come on,” Joseph said. “Here, I’ll help you.”

His hand reached down for me, but all I could see was a cloudy mist. Old Man appeared before me.

“Isaac, I am worried for my grandson. You must warn Joseph. He must be very careful. The soldiers are waiting for him. They know he is here.”

“We want to find Naomi,” I said.

“You must go alone, Isaac. They will not hurt you. Go to the Choctaw Council wagon. Tell them your father sent you to help them. Joseph can stay in the woods. He can look out for you, but he must not be seen.”

“What should I do?”

“While you are working, keep an eye out for Naomi. I will be there.” As suddenly as he appeared, Old Man was gone. I looked at Joseph, sitting on a tree limb.

“You saw a ghost, didn’t you?” he said.

“Yes. It was your grandfather.”

“What did he say?”

I climbed the tree before I spoke. What I said was too important to yell out loud, for anyone to hear. When I sat next to him, I spoke in a whisper.

“Joseph, your grandfather is scared for you. He told me to warn you. The soldiers know you are here.”

“How can they know that?”

“I don’t know, but your grandfather is speaking the truth. He is a ghost. He sees things people can’t see.”

“We are going to rescue Naomi,” Joseph said. “Did you tell him that? I wish I could talk to him.”

“Yes, I told him. He has a plan.” I told Joseph about me helping the Choctaw councilmen, in the wagon close to Naomi.

“I’ll stay close, as close as I can,” Joseph said. Then he bowed his head and spoke in a quiet and serious voice.

“I know these soldiers,” he said. “I know what they will do. Isaac, when you see them, when you get close to them, remember they are the same men who burned our houses down while we slept inside. They tried to burn us all, burn us alive. And when that didn’t work, they acted so kind and gave us blankets. The blankets killed most of our friends.”

“I know. I remember,” I said. “I try not to be afraid, Joseph, but I am more afraid than I’ve ever been in my life.”

“And you are smart to be,” he said, lifting his eyes to mine.

We climbed down the tree and made our way through the woods. Thinking of Joseph’s warning, I stayed in the shadows, moving as quietly as I could from one clump of trees to the next.

“Be careful how you step,” Joseph whispered. “The soldiers send out patrols. If they hear the leaves rattle, they won’t wait to see what it is. They’ll fire their shotguns. Nothing would make them happier than to kill two Choctaw boys sneaking through the woods.”

The forest was thick with snaking vines and bushes at the base of the trees. I knew no Choctaw farmers had ever lived here. By nightfall we neared the council wagon.

“*Hoke*,” Joseph said, pointing to the wagon. “Here’s where you take over.”

“Joseph, don’t say that! I need you now more than ever.”

“Sorry,” he said. “I’ll be right with you, invisible as a ghost,” he joked.

I stepped from the woods to the camp. Ten older Choctaw men and women sat by the fire, eating bowls of *pashofa*. A thin man with gray hair stood when I entered the camp.

“*Halito*,” he said. “Welcome to our camp.”

"Yakoke," I replied.

"I am Nani Humma, and these are my fellow Choctaw councilmen," he said, gesturing to the circle of people.

"My name is Isaac," I replied. "I am from a small town in the swamps to the south. I would like to offer my help. I can gather wood, make a fire. I can hunt and fish if you need me to."

The councilmen laughed.

"We get our food from the supply wagon," said Nani Humma. He was smiling, but I could see he was trying his best not to laugh at me. I liked him already. "Do you have family on the walk?" he asked.

“Yes, my mother and father and a big brother.”

“They will be worried about you, Isaac,” Nani Humma said. “You should let them know where you are.”

“My parents gave me permission to leave our camp,” I said. I hated lying to Nani Humma. And although I hadn’t really told a lie, I was not telling him the whole truth. I decided to tell him everything, as soon as I could.

“Isaac,” said Nani Humma. “*Yakoke* for your kind offer. If you will wait by the wagon, we need to talk for a few minutes.”

I moved to the road and stood by the wagon. I watched as the councilmen huddled together. They spoke quietly, and I knew they were deciding what to do about me. After only a few minutes, Nani Humma stood and waved.

“*Hoke*, Isaac,” he said. I stood before the Choctaw Council. I knew this was an important day for me.

"We have decided that you can join us," Nani Humma said.

"*Yakoke*," I said, nodding to everyone. "I will show you every respect."

I was greeted with warm smiles as I walked from one to another. They each took my hand and said nice things to me. I felt welcomed.

"Have you had supper yet?" Nani Humma asked.

"Let me get you a bowl of soup," said a councilwoman.

"Please," I said. "I am here to help you. Let me serve myself."

The councilmen laughed again, a laugh that let me know they were glad I was there. After supper, I took the bowls to the creek and washed them clean. I scattered the logs and put out the fire. I even helped a very old man to his feet.

Nani Humma gave me a thick blanket. "You can sleep by the fire," he said. "If it rains, we have a small tent by the wagon. Climb inside and sleep by the door."

For a brief moment, I wished everything was different. I wished I was not on a mission to rescue Naomi. I wished I were the helper of the Choctaw Council, not a boy who would soon be a ghost. *Maybe I can be a Choctaw councilman someday*, I thought.

Then I returned to the real world. *I could never be a Choctaw councilman. They would never elect a ghost to be a councilman.*

I hoped that my first night with the Choctaw Council would be peaceful. But that was not to be. Nani Humma was smarter than I thought. He knew I had a secret, and it didn't take him long to learn the truth.



Chapter 16

Seeking Naomi

I THOUGHT everyone was asleep. I'd heard old men snoring. But not every old man snores. I thought I had fooled them all, and anyway I had to talk to Joseph. I climbed from my blanket and walked to the creek.

"Joseph?" I whispered. "Are you here?"

"Yes," he said, stepping from behind a big cypress tree. "Good job."

"Isaac, who is your friend?" In the quiet woods of night, the voice of Nani Humma boomed like a shotgun. I jumped like I was the target.

Nani Humma stepped from the shadows. I hung my head and said nothing.

“I already know Isaac, but we have not met,” said Nani Humma, stepping to Joseph and offering his hand. Joseph and I stood still, ashamed and caught.

“I won’t wake up the council, not at this late hour,” said Nani Humma. “But you will tell me what is going on, and you will tell me now.”

Joseph and I told Nani Humma the whole story. For almost an hour we talked. We told him of the burning of our homes. Joseph told of his escape. We told him about Naomi and our mission to rescue her. We told him of the soldiers, and how Joseph’s life was in danger. I even told him about seeing the ghosts.

When I saw that he believed us, I told him my biggest secret.

“I will soon be a ghost,” I said in a whisper. I looked at Nani Humma, hoping he would believe me. He said nothing, but he nodded to let me know he understood.

When we finished talking, Nani Humma sat in silence for the longest time. Finally he stood up, brushed the leaves from his pants, and spoke.

“The hour is late and we need our sleep. Isaac, you can stay with us for now. Joseph, as long as you cause no trouble, you are welcome, too. I don’t think I have to tell you how important it is that you stay out of sight.”

“I understand,” Joseph said.

“*Yakoke*,” I replied.

The next morning Nani Humma told the Choctaw Council about our nighttime visit. I finished serving breakfast and sat down to listen. When Nani Humma came to the part about Naomi, and how she had been taken, the councilmen gave fire to their anger.

“They took a young girl from her family?”

“They use her like a slave!”

“Her family thought she was dead! How horrible.”

When everyone had had their say, Mister Tibbi stood to speak. He was the head of the council and a large man, thick as a tree trunk. Gray hair fell about his face and down his shoulders.

“If we approach these soldiers and accuse them of keeping this girl against her will, they will lie,” he said. “The girl will be afraid of what they will do to her and her family if she tells the truth. She might never see her family again, or worse, she might disappear.”

“What do you suggest we do?” Nani Humma asked.

“If Naomi is ever to return to her family, I think her best chance lies with these young men, our new helper, Isaac, and his friend Joseph. We can lend a hand when needed. We can keep an eye out for the girl. But we must do these things in secret. We cannot endanger our people.”

There were nods all around.

Joseph and I stood a little straighter. Rescuing Naomi gave us all a purpose. I noticed it right away.

The councilwomen walked faster than usual that morning, leaving our wagon behind. When we stopped for our noon meal, the women kept walking. They waved to the soldiers, saying, "We know there are berries in these woods. If we find any, we'll make berry pudding. It's an old Choctaw recipe. You will love it!"

The soldiers smiled and waved back.

“We’ll hold you to that promise!” the soldiers shouted.

I knew better than to follow the women, not on my first full day with the council, but I listened and heard the friendly talk.

These councilwomen are smart, I thought. They are gaining the soldiers’ trust.

While I built the fire that evening, the women reported to the council.

“We saw her,” said Stella. She was the eldest, a white-haired, thin woman. “We saw Naomi. When she heard us speaking to the soldiers, she peeked around the back of the wagon. She was curious, but I could tell she did not want us to see her.”

“She is afraid for her family,” said Nani Humma. “The soldiers said they would harm her little sister if she caused any trouble.”

“She was dressed like a boy,” Stella said, “just like we expected. But anyone who looked closely could see she is a strong young girl.”

“A terrified young girl,” said another woman.

“What do you think we should do now?” Nani Humma asked.

“Let the boys do their job,” said Mister Tibbi.